"kinda took it easy *yet*": *non-polar yet* in Michigan English

Annan Kirk | Michigan State University | kirkann1@msu.edu | annankirk.github.io

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Introduction

The time adverb *yet* is typically illicit in affirmative sentences (Quirk et al., 1972; Levinson, 2008)

1. He is not here **yet**.
2. * He is here **yet**.

However, some USA English speakers produce and accept *yet* in environments that do *not* license negative polarity items (NPI).

3. We … are quite busy **yet** (Bagwell et al., 2019)
4. They're down at the smokehouse **yet** (Gillner, 2026)

Where are people saying this? (**Figure 1**)

"I just don't hear people in Indiana use **yet** like that, as in, in the place of *still*." (MI Diaries Corpus, MCD-00932)

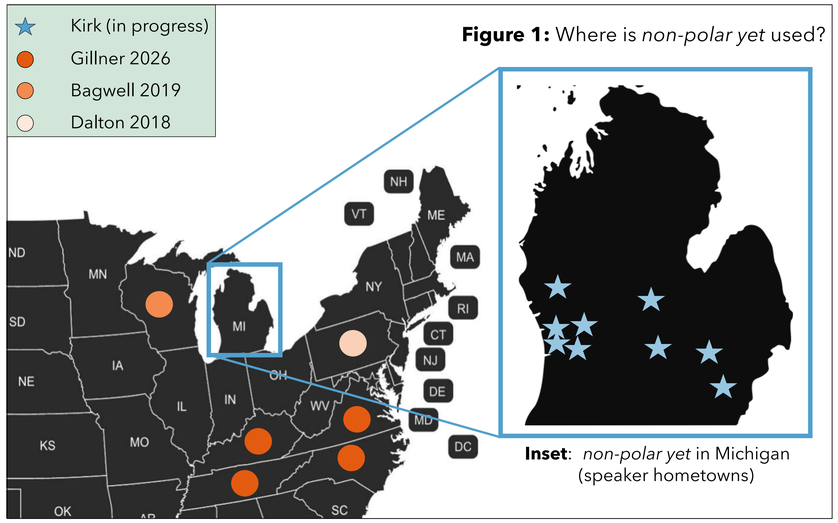


Figure 1: Where is *non-polar yet* used?

Inset: *non-polar yet* in Michigan (speaker hometowns)

Research Questions

1. Is *non-polar yet* a remnant on its way out, or is it spreading?
   - Who is saying this? Where are they saying it?

2. What does *non-polar yet* mean to speakers who use it?
   - How does TAM affect the meaning?

What does it mean?

Implies "**continuance from a previous time** up to and including the present time (or some other stated time). **Now chiefly regional**." (Oxford English Dictionary)

5. … he spoke the language pretty well **yet**. (1756)
6. I can feel them **yet**. (2011)

Non-polar *yet* **asserts** that X is happening **now** and **presupposes** that X happened in the **past.** (Dalton, 2018; Gillner, 2026)

But this isn't the full picture!

Preliminary Data

Judgements from native speaker informants + MI Diaries corpus, a longitudinal collection of self-recorded audio from speakers living in Michigan (Sneller & Wagner, 2020-).

7. …kinda took it easy **yet** on Saturday. (MCD-00235)

Informants & diarists are all from **different areas of Michigan**. (**Inset**)

There is some **interaction with TAM** (tense/aspect/mood):

8a. Last month he **ate** meat **yet**. (Regi, DC)
8b. ? Last month, he **had been eating** meat **yet**
8c. * He **had eaten** meat **yet**.

Future directions

- Reading on TAM, NPIs, positive *anymore*
- Expanded corpus search
- More detailed sociolx histories for informants
- Acceptability judgement experiment

Qs FOR PROJECT LAUNCH ATTENDEES

- Can you say this?
- Suggestions for further reading?
- Suggestions for next steps?

Corpus: **Sneller, B. & Wagner, S**. MI Diaries corpus. 2020-. https://mi-diaries.org/
References: **Bagwell, A., Litty, S., & Olson, M.** (2019). Wisconsin immigrant letters: German transfer to Wisconsin English. In R. Hickey (Ed.), *Keeping in touch: Emigrant letters across the English-speaking world*. John Benjamins Publishing Company. **Dalton, C.** (2018). *The interplay of conversational implicature, speaker expectations, and NPI and positive* anymore *and* yet. BA Thesis, Bryn Mawr College. **Gillner, M.** (2026). *Veridicality of Time Adverbial NPIs* Anymore *and* Yet. BA Thesis, Pennsylvania State University. **Levinson, D.** (2008). *Licensing of negative polarity particles* yet, anymore, either *and* neither*: Combining downward monotonicity and assertivity.* Dissertation, Stanford University. **Oxford University Press**. (n.d.). Yet, adv., II.5.a. In Oxford English dictionary. Retrieved August 1, 2026, from https://doi.org/10.1093/OED/8398664105. **Quirk, R., Greenbaum, S., Leech, G., and Svartvik, J.** (1972). *A Grammar of contemporary English*. Longman Publishing Group.